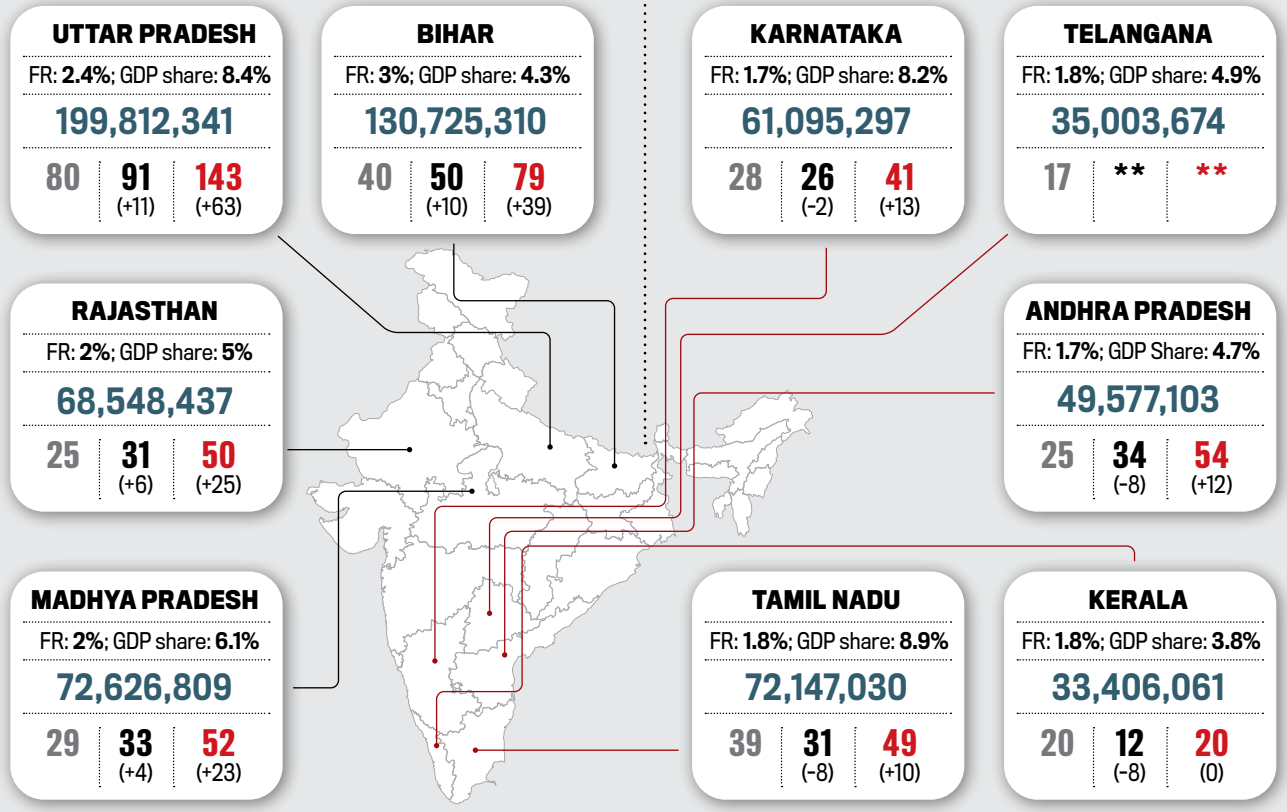
BIGGEST GAINERS

Four north Indian states, which comprise 39 per cent of the country's population and have fertility rates above 2, are projected to gain 31 Lok Sabha seats. Their representation will rise from 32 per cent to 38 per cent of the total seats, bringing their total to 205. These states currently contribute 24 per cent to India's national GDP. If total Lok Sabha seats are increased to 848, these states will gain 150 seats, an 86 per cent increase compared to national average increase of 56 per cent

BIGGEST LOSERS

The five south Indian states, which currently contribute 31% to India's GDP and account for 21 per cent of the population, will see a reduction of 26 Lok Sabha seats due to their low fertility rates (1.8 or below). Their representation will decrease from 24 per cent to 19 per cent of the total Lok Sabha seats, leaving them with 103 seats. Even if seats are increased to 848, they stand to gain 35 seats, a mere 27 per cent increase compared to the 56 per cent hike in total Lok Sabha seats



Total population | Current LS seats | 2026 projected seats | 2026 projected seats if LS seats are increased to 848

Gain/ Loss in ( ); FR: Fertility rate; GDP share: Share of national GDP; **Telangana projections not available

Sources: Census 2011, NFHS-5, A 2019 study by Milan Vaishnav and Jamie Hintson

Graphics by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**

women's representation contingent on a redrawing of constituencies, the BJP has not only ensured that delimitation becomes inevitable but has also reframed the debate—turning what was once a contentious electoral restructuring into a matter of gender justice. This dual-purpose strategy puts the pressure on Opposition parties, especially those from the South, to accept delimitation while simultaneously deflecting criticism of delaying women's reservation by tying it to constitutional requirements.

Union home minister Amit Shah has dismissed Stalin's concerns outright, asserting that "Tamil Nadu will not lose a single seat" and saying that PM Modi has assured the southern states that their representation will not be diminished. State BJP chief K. Annamalai has also slammed Stalin for spouting "imaginary fears" and misleading the public. The contradiction between the alarm call by the southern leaders and the BJP's stand has turned delimitation into a new political flashpoint, with Stalin warning that a "sword is hanging over the southern states".

What is delimitation?

The process of delimitation in India is guided by the Constitution, which mandates periodic reallocation of parliamentary and state assembly constituencies based on population changes. Article 82 of the Constitution stipulates that after each Census, the allocation of seats in the Lok Sabha and state legislative assemblies should be readjusted to ensure proportional representation. Similarly, Article 170 governs the division of seats for state assemblies. This process is carried out by the Delimitation Com-